

SHAILESH RAVAL



MIXED MESSAGE: Gujarat CM Modi; Folmsbee (right)

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Renowned violinist **Kunnakudi Valdyanathan** after a brief illness. He was 73.

WON: The ONGC IBSF World Billiards Championship (point format) by **Pankaj Advani**. He beat Geet Sethi



to win the ultimate trophy in the instant version of the cue sport.

CONFERRED: The *Forbes* Lifetime Achievement Award to **Lakshmi Mittal**, the London-based NRI steel tycoon. This is the highest recognition of global business success bestowed by the US business magazine.

AWARDED: The Asam Ratna Award to musician **Bhupen Hazarika** in recognition of his seminal contribution to Assamese culture.

FRAMED: Charges against Dera Sacha Sauda chief **Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh** in in one rape and two murder cases by a special CBI court in Ambala.

Yearning for Visa Power

AHMEDABAD Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi's visa is fast becoming the albatross around US authorities' necks—and a question that will not go away. Under pressure from several human rights groups, the US denied the Gujarat chief minister visa three years ago, causing heartburn and outrage across Modi's substantial fan base in the US. The visa stayed elusive this year again, as Modi remained unable to travel to the US to address a World

Gujarati meet held at New Jersey and had to address the gathering via satellite. Naturally, the Gujaratis were somewhat perplexed by what happened next.

Paul Folmsbee, US Consul General in the Mumbai Consulate, went to great lengths to praise Gujarat's rapid economic progress at a function organised to celebrate the fourth anniversary of the American Corner at the Ahmedabad Management Association. Gujarat, said Folmsbee, had always

been a progressive state with cutting-edge businesses. Yet when asked about the visa issue for the controversial chief minister, Folmsbee remained silent saying, "The issue is confidential." What he did admit to the reporters was that he was going to meet Modi soon.

Powerful US-based Gujarati NRIs were left scratching their heads. In order to bring Modi over Stateside, they had gone into an overdrive in trying to convince the US administration to grant Modi entry. The chief minister was pitched to the US visa authorities as an irresistible combination: the great administrator and bulwark against terrorism. And as if the double whammy wasn't enough, Modi was also presented as a future prime minister of India. But no dice, no visa.

The US, as Folmsbee seemed to indicate in Ahmedabad, loves shaking hands with Gujarat but is content to keep its alpha male at arm's length. **by Uday Mahurkar**

VIS-A-VIS MIRWAIZ UMER FAROOQ Hurriyat Conference chairman **versus** MUKHTAR ABBAS NAQVI BJP leader

Hurriyat Conference rejects elections. It is also not an issue of governance. Kashmir issue cannot be resolved through polls.



SAURABH SINGH

The BJP wants elections in the state by October-end or November. The EC should not succumb to pressure from separatists.

EPILOGUE: First the Amarnath issue, and now elections—the state can never heave a breath of relief.